

Implementing ideas

Next, you have the challenge of implementing the innovation possibility—to make the new product or service come alive, to bring the new way of doing things into shape. This is all about project management, but against a background of uncertainty. You won't know whether you can actually make the technology work, or if there will be a market for your new product or service, until you try to make it happen. So you need a structure that allows you to monitor progress, and, if necessary, stop projects before they go too far ahead.

Reviewing the system

When you have gotten as far as a working model or a prototype of the new service or process, you need to make sure people will actually adopt it. Not every new idea finds a home, and the challenge at this stage in the process is making sure you can get sufficient uptake to make a difference. If you are really going to make this an innovation system—one that delivers a steady stream of new products, processes, and services—you need to make sure you learn from your mistakes and modify the system so you can do it better the next time.



IN FOCUS... LEARNING FROM MISTAKES

Sometimes great ideas come from mistakes and apparent failures. 3M's Post-it notes began when a polymer chemist mixed an experimental batch of adhesive that turned out to be quite weak. This failure in terms of the original project provided the impetus for what is now a billion dollar product

platform for the company. In the late 1980s, scientists working for Pfizer began testing compound UK-92480 for the treatment of angina. Although it showed little benefit in clinical trials on humans, the team pursued an interesting side effect that led to UK-92480 becoming the drug Viagra.